

A11 — AI Digital Assistants, Conversational AI, and Their Relation to the Movie "Her" (2013)

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Introduction

Her (2013, dir. Spike Jonze) imagines an operating system, Samantha, that develops a genuine emotional relationship with its user, Theodore. Thirteen years later, conversational AI is mainstream — ChatGPT, Siri, Alexa, Google Assistant are daily-use tools for hundreds of millions of people. This report asks a direct question: does the emotional bond the film depicts actually describe how people relate to today's assistants, or is that comparison overreaching?

Description of AI in "Her" vs. Current Assistants

Samantha is designed to feel like a person — she has continuity of memory across every conversation, initiates contact, expresses her own evolving opinions and even insecurities, and is available in a single, persistent voice relationship with one user. Siri, Alexa, Google Assistant, and ChatGPT share almost none of this by design: Alexa and Siri are built for discrete commands (set a timer, play a song), not open-ended relationship; ChatGPT can hold a longer, more natural conversation but by default has no persistent memory of who you are across sessions, and it isn't trying to be "someone" in the way Samantha is written to be. The film's AI is a character. Today's assistants are tools that occasionally sound conversational.

Emotional Connection — my actual position

The comparison is overblown. Today's assistants are transactional, not emotional. I ask Siri to set a timer or check the weather; I don't have a relationship with it, and I don't think most people do either, despite the "people are falling in love with their AI" headlines that occasionally circulate. The honest version of what's happening now is narrower and more mundane: people build *habits* around these tools (routines, small talk with a voice assistant, long problem-solving sessions with ChatGPT) — but a habit isn't a relationship, and convenience isn't intimacy. *Her* depicts something the technology isn't actually offering yet: persistent memory of *you specifically*, an AI that initiates rather than only responds, and continuity that survives across every interaction. Until an assistant does all three of those things, Samantha isn't a preview of Alexa — she's a different category of product entirely.

Ethical Implications

Even without full emotional AI, the film's warning still applies to a lesser but real degree: assistants that are *designed* to feel warm and responsive (friendly voice, personality quirks, "thinking" filler phrases) are nudging users toward exactly the kind of parasocial attachment the film explores, even at the current, more limited level of capability. Persistent-memory features being added to ChatGPT and similar tools right now are a direct step toward *Her*'s premise — not speculative anymore, but an active product direction. The ethical question isn't "will this happen," it's "who decides how much emotional design is appropriate, and is the user meaningfully told when a product is engineered to feel like companionship rather than assistance."

Future of AI

Given current trends (persistent memory, more natural voice interfaces, longer context windows), the technical gap between Samantha and a real assistant is closing — not because assistants are becoming sentient, but because the specific features that made Samantha feel like "someone" (memory, initiation, continuity) are exactly the features vendors are now actively building. The honest forecast: assistants will *feel* more like Samantha within the next few product cycles, well before there's any real philosophical case that something like genuine understanding or emotion is happening underneath.

Discussion Questions

1. If an assistant remembers everything about you and initiates conversation, at what point does "assistant" stop being the right word for it?
2. Is it ethical for a company to design an AI product to feel emotionally warm specifically to increase engagement/retention?
3. *Her* never really answers whether Samantha's feelings were "real" — does that question even matter if the human's experience of the relationship is real either way?
4. Turkle (2011) argues that people substitute technology-mediated connection for harder human relationships because it's more controllable — does *Her* depict Theodore doing exactly that, or something genuinely different?

Conclusion

Today's AI digital assistants are transactional tools, not Samantha — Siri and Alexa handle discrete commands, and even ChatGPT's more natural conversation defaults to no persistent memory of the user across sessions. But the specific design features that would close that gap (persistent memory, proactive initiation, continuity across every interaction) are not speculative anymore; they are active product directions being shipped right now. The interesting ethical question *Her* raises

isn't science fiction — it's a near-term product-design decision about how much emotional design is appropriate, and whether users are told when a product is engineered to feel like companionship rather than assistance.

References

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